Frontotemporal dementia (FTD)

Frontotemporal dementia (FTD) is one of the less common types of dementia. It covers a range of different conditions that can affect personality, behaviour and language.

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Frontotemporal dementia

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What is frontotemporal dementia (FTD)?

FTD is mostly diagnosed in people under 65. It is sometimes called frontal lobe dementia and used to be called Pick's disease.

The word 'frontotemporal' refers to two sets of lobes (frontal and temporal) in the brain. FTD occurs when disease damages nerve cells in these lobes. This causes the connections between them and other parts of the brain to break down.

As more and more nerve cells are damaged and die, the brain tissue in the frontal and temporal lobes gets smaller.

Types of FTD

There are two types of FTD:

- **Behavioural variant FTD**
  Damage to the frontal lobes of the brain mainly causes problems with behaviour and personality. These lobes are found behind the forehead. They process information and influence how we think, behave and manage our emotions.
- **Primary progressive aphasia (PPA)**
  Damage to the temporal lobes initially causes difficulties with language. Some people have trouble remembering words and names of objects. Others may struggle to speak at their usual speed or to use words in the right order. This is known as 'language-led' dementia. The temporal lobes are on either
  side of the head, nearest the ears.

The first noticeable symptoms for a person with FTD will be changes to their personality and behaviour, or difficulties with language. Sometimes it can involve both. This is very different from the early symptoms of more common types of dementia.

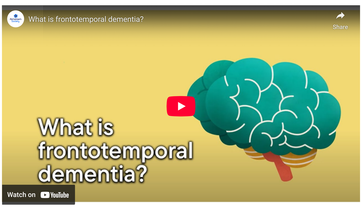
For example, in Alzheimer's disease, early changes are often problems with short-term memory. Many people with FTD don't have a significant problem with their memory during the early stage of their condition.

Advice

Dementia and the brain

Knowing more about the brain and how it can change can help to understand the symptoms of dementia. It can help a person with dementia to live well, or to support a person with dementia to live well.

Read more →



Frontotemporal dementia symptoms

Frontotemporal dementia (FTD) affects everyone differently. Its symptoms depend on which areas of the frontal and temporal lobes are damaged. As with most forms of dementia, FTD is progressive. This means its symptoms may be mild at first, but they will get worse over time.

+ Behavioural variant FTD
+ Primary progressive aphasia (language variants of frontotemporal dementia)
+ Later stages of FTD
+ Related conditions that affect movement

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2. Who gets frontotemporal dementia?

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Frontotemporal dementia (FTD), Young-onset dementia

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Real stories

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